

Spanish Grand Prix – Fastest lap comparison; Russell vs Hamilton:

Qualifying for the 2026 Spanish GP saw George Russell take his third pole position of the season, closely followed by the most successful driver in F1 history, seven-time World Champion Lewis Hamilton.

Below is an overlay of the publicly available telemetry data for both cars, and a follow-up brief discussion on the differences between the two laps:

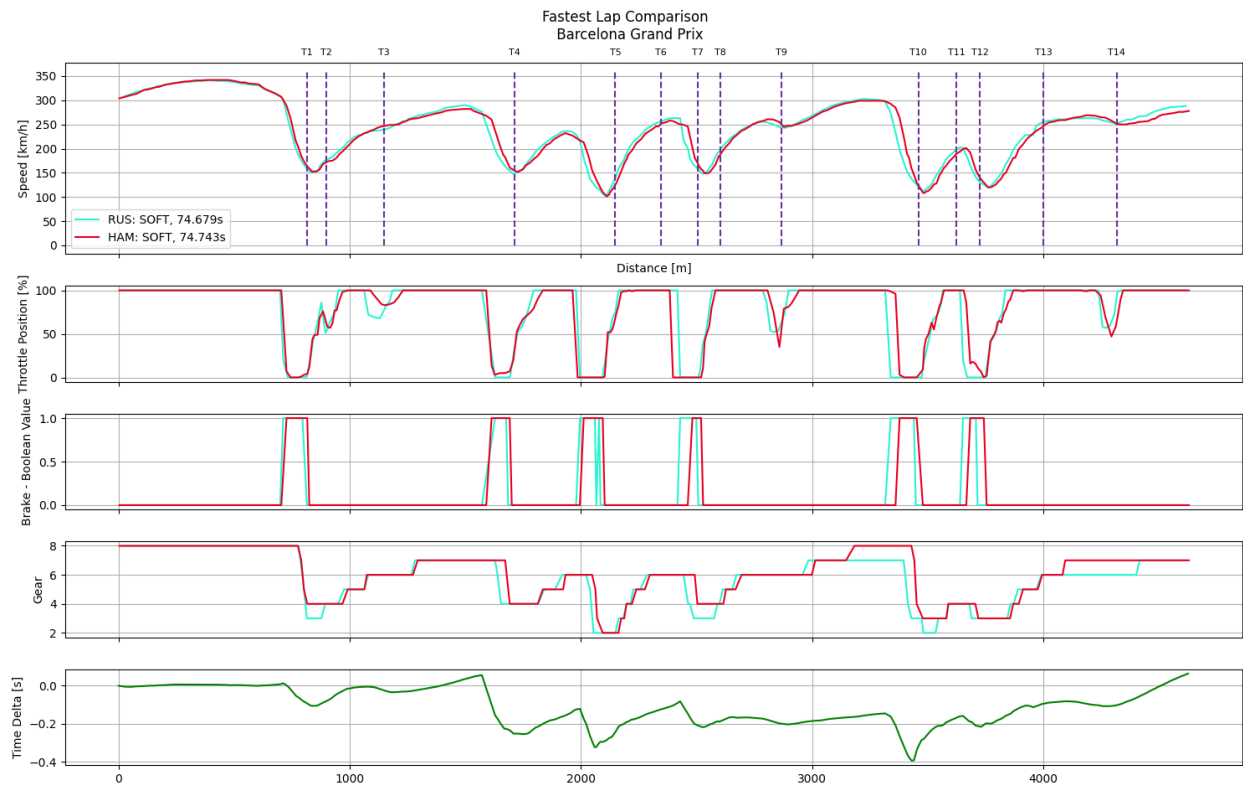


Figure 1: RUS vs HAM fastest lap comparison

There are a few interesting things to discuss after reviewing the telemetry we have:

- Hamilton rolls ~10 km/h more speed through T1, gaining an early advantage of ~0.1s, but Russell gets on throttle ~20m earlier and reclaims the ~0.1s loss and gains an additional ~0.05s on the run to T4.
- Hamilton rolls ~28 km/h more speed through T4, ~12 km/h through T5, ~30 km/h through T7, resulting in a net gain of 0.25s on Russell. Hamilton gains a further ~0.19s by rolling an additional ~50 km/h through T10, but this ~0.19s advantage was reclaimed by Russell, who got better acceleration on the exit of T10. The speed differential on corner entry indicates Ferrari are running a higher downforce package than Mercedes.
- Russell gains ~0.26s from the exit of T11, T12 and through the exit of T14, likely due to a combination of differences in deployment strategies and downforce packages.

An important note is that battery deployment, and downforce values are not publicly available, rather these are inferred from both the speed trace, and the time delta trace, and throttle/braking traces. T2, T3, T8, T9 and T13 were not ignored, rather no significant differences could be inferred from the available data.